



▲ Breaking boundaries

Through his work with the people of the Trobriand Islands, Malinowski laid the foundations of modern social anthropology. He published his research in the 1920s.

BEYOND SUPERSTITION

the colonial anthropologist

For anthropologists in the late 19th century, the use of “ritual magic” by tribal societies marked them out as less developed than their Western counterparts—a view that is now considered both outdated and racist. Anthropology (the study of human societies) was then a relatively new and evolving discipline, and ideas about tribal ritual radically altered during the 20th century.

In the field

In 1915, the Polish-born anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski began his fieldwork. His results dramatically changed anthropologists’ views on the practice of magic. Studying the Trobriand islanders of Melanesia (part of Oceania), he lived among the people for several years, spoke their language, and observed their customs. Magic was widely practiced by islanders, and—whether applied to canoe-

building, yam-planting, or healing—it involved reciting magical formulae, sometimes combined with a ritual. Malinowski concluded that this magic was not rooted in superstition, but had both a logical basis (helping with practical daily tasks) and a crucial social role in creating a common identity. He also noted parallels

► Ancestral connection

The Azande people placed great importance in the five-stringed *kundi* harp. The carved head on the neck signifies that the music produced is from their ancestors.

